

regret it for one second.”

When relationships build and break over e-mails and IMs, why should a game world offer less? Indeed it offers much more. People find that they have gained confidence and are more assertive in their life. And why not? They just organised 300 people from across the globe to get together and slay evil. An exercise highly recommended for the self-esteem.



Dark Age of Camelot: A land of dragons and magic

A lucky few find that ever-elusive thing called love, even hope—in an online survey, 31 per cent of respondents claimed to be more benevolent within a game than they are in real life. Some even use online quests as substitute therapy: “I find myself much more satisfied venting my stress through repeated slashes of an imaginary sword on an imaginary creature and having someone there to listen without the face-to-face, truly personal connection other mediums of therapy offer,” says an *Asheron’s Call* player. “Plus it costs a lot less per month. And while

this does certainly sound quite like a narcotic, I would rather be dependent on a game world than on a more damaging physical drug that wouldn’t offer the same connection with others nor the true tranquillity, as opposed to an artificial hallucination as a result of some recreational pharmaceutical.”

The darker side is desperate addiction and a paranoid schizophrenia that rises from the pits of a CD-ROM disk. You will, thus, come across cases such as that of a mom who sued industry giant and owners of *EverQuest*, Sony, after her son killed himself. Or like that of a father who nurses a similar grievance over his son who committed suicide after a failed online, in-game relationship. While the mom tried to attract media attention to a very real problem, dad started an online forum where those addicted to games in

general and MMORPGs in particular, share their experiences and hopes. You may also hear of the Korean boy who died at his keyboard because he neglected his health for days together, over a game. Or the college student who played so much that he imagined orcs and goblins in the real world, chasing him into the arms of insanity.

You dream it, we build it

If the pixellated mess that represents games such as *Ultima Online* and *EverQuest* generate such emotions, what will the



next wave of titles bring to shore? *EverQuest* has more than 433,000 paying customers who generate \$5 million (almost Rs 25 crore) a month for the Japanese giant. It is thus without surprise that realms that promise much more are popping up all over.

If dragon slaying doesn’t appeal to you, kind sir, may we interest you in this world, where you can be a nefarious sea-pirate! Or how about this one, if you wish to take to space and fulfil every *Star Trek* fantasy? You can zoom around stars, between wormholes, inside your Frigate class ship, taking down rogues and villains, or being one! Mine the asteroids, establish trade routes and trade organisations. Heck! You can buy this planet right here! We will throw in a moon for beauty’s sake. There is much more sir, much, much more. You can jack yourself into the online world of *The Matrix*, or grab a lightsaber and flow with the Force in a digital rendition of the *Star Wars* universe. Someone else? A superhero perhaps? A lone, desperate gun fighting for survival in an equally desperate post-apocalyptic, cyberpunk world? Gandalf from *The Lord of the Rings*? What’s that you say? You want to be a rock star? Well, step right up and take to the stage. Do mind the dwarves, kind sir, they are a sensitive lot.

As technology advances on the warhorse of faster hardware and the

EverCrack

“I’m not ugly, stupid or selfish. I don’t understand why he would choose imaginary people over me”

Melody P,

Wife to an *EverQuest* addict

“I call myself an addict, because I share the same symptoms as someone who’s addicted to smoking or alcohol, or some other substance. I think about EQ while I’m not playing. I get stressed when I have to go 24 hrs without logging on for a fix, and I wasn’t able to quit when I tried. If that’s not an addiction, I don’t know what is”

Male, age 22,

An *EverQuest* addict